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Preserving quality journalism

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New legislation requiring Big Tech to pay news agencies when using their digital content revealed a split among Assembly members representing Ventura County.

One voted in favor of the California Journalism Preservation Act, while the other two did not vote on the bill.

The bill, authored by Assemblymember Buffy Wicks (D-Oakland) as a way to help struggling local media outlets, passed 46-6 and is now with the state Senate.

AB 886 would require social media companies Meta, Google, Twitter and others of similar size to pay a percentage of advertising revenue—determined through arbitration—as a journalism usage fee to news organizations that produce content shared on those platforms.

But the outlets couldn't just pocket the money. Seventy percent of those funds would have to be spent on journalists and support staff.

The bill has the support of the California News Publishers Association, which says it gives news organizations "a chance to get paid for their original content when Big Tech scrapes it from the internet or displays it in response to searches and keeps the vast majority of attendant search and ad revenue . . . all without investing a dime in the expense of employing the journalists who produce it."

Assemblymember Jacqui Irwin, a Democrat whose 42nd District includes Camarillo, Moorpark, Thousand Oaks and Simi Valley, did not vote on the bill.

"I applaud the intent of AB 886 as it seeks to support journalism and newspapers," she said.

However, the bill as written, she said, "could have significant unintended consequences that would only enrich the out-of-state private equity funds that own them. Supporting a free press is too important an issue to gamble away when we are already seeing a significant decline in local reporting and newspapers."

The other local Assembly member in the no-vote-registered category is Jesse Gabriel, a Democrat whose L.A. County heavy 46th District includes most of the San Fernando Valley and a small portion of eastern Ventura County, including unincorporated Bell Canyon.

Democratic Assemblymember Steve Bennett, whose 38th District includes Oxnard, voted for the bill.

Bennett said in a statement, "We have seen the disturbing trend of local news organizations increasingly struggle under a variety of factors. As the internet landscape drastically changes with emergent technology, platforms, and users, I am supportive of giving journalists appropriate compensation for the use and distribution of their content."

The Assembly vote came one day after Facebook and Instagram parent company Meta threatened to take all news content off its platforms if the bill becomes law.

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